

what's expected from them, in their local language."

Dhoni (**below**) also held regular conversations with the players ahead of the season, where they could ask him anything about the game. During one session with the senior team, he urged the youngsters to be mentally tough. As one player recalled, Dhoni referenced the Indian team and cited specific incidents to underline the importance of mental strength in crunch moments.

"He was talking to all the players, in every format; whether it is the women's team or men's, Under-19 or senior, U-23. He was involved in everything. And he gave his input. He also had individual sessions with players. He has given at least a couple of hours for each team," Nadeem said, before adding, "So, a lot of the success can be credited to him as well because of his involvement and the time he gave, despite a busy schedule. He listened patiently to everyone and also suggested improvements to the infrastructure, which we followed."

One of Dhoni's key recommendations was to rejig the State's domestic cricket cycle. For years, age-group cricket had leaned heavily towards white-ball formats. Keeping the game's evolving demands in mind, Dhoni stressed the importance of introducing multi-day cricket at the junior level. According to Tiwary and Nadeem, that proved to be a game-changer. "We reworked the domestic structure, particularly at the junior level. Earlier, age-group cricket was mostly limited-overs, but we have now introduced two-day games at the U-16 and U-19 levels," Nadeem said.

Once facilities were in place, the bigger task was getting the best out of the players. Ishan led from the front, setting the tone early. In meetings ahead of the SMAT, he assured the players would be given a longer rope and not judged on a couple of performances.

That assurance made a difference. Ahead of the group-stage matches in Ahmedabad, roles and expectations were clearly defined. "As a team, we know we not only have to play our

roles to perfection, but also step up for a teammate who might have one bad day. That's how we complement each other and move forward," said vice-captain Kumar Kushagra, one of the architects of the title run.

Ishan understood how to get the best out of his squad. He kept everyone invested, including those outside the playing XI, and fostered a sense of togetherness. He also took responsibility for tactical missteps and rough patches. "Players knew that no matter what, he would back them, and as captain, he would own the mistakes. When your captain leads by example, things become easier," Kushagra added.

Team effort

Ishan set the tone with explosive starts throughout the tournament. Kushagra added stability at the top and stepped up in the final with a 38-ball 81 when opener Virat Singh faltered. "We were just playing game by game," Ishan said, while Kushagra pointed to the importance of staying composed. "We knew what to do and didn't complicate matters," he said.

That clarity filtered through the order. Players like Robin Minz and Anukul Roy dropped down the lineup and still produced impact innings. "As a unit, we never lost hope," Ishan said. "Even in tough situations, we believed we could change the game."

It showed in the performances. When the seamers struggled, Anukul, Player of the Tournament with 303 runs and 18 wickets, delivered the breakthroughs. On days the spinners were taken apart, the fast bowlers responded. "It was about the right balance and cutting out the noise," Kushagra said.

Unbeaten in the group stage, Jharkhand carried momentum into the Super League in Pune. There were minor tweaks, but no panic. Calmness held in tight moments, and belief did not waver.

By the time the final arrived, Jharkhand were not chasing a dream anymore. They were executing a plan.

BY THE NUMBERS

262/3

Jharkhand vs Haryana
Highest total in a final of any recognised T20 tournament

2

Ishan Kishan becomes only the second batter to score a SMAT final hundred

5

Ishan Kishan's hundreds in SMAT - joint most with Abhishek Sharma

517 runs

Ishan Kishan finishes third on the all-time SMAT single-season run list

1884 sixes

Most sixes in any T20 tournament ever



K. MURALI KUMAR